The Railway Children

A simplified retelling

Original story by E. Nesbit

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. The evening everything changed

Roberta, Peter and Phyllis lived comfortably in London with their parents. Then two men came to see their father. He left with them, and their mother would not explain where he had gone.

Soon the family moved to a small house in the country near a railway. Their mother wrote stories to earn money. The children had to become careful about food, clothes and requests that cost anything.

Roberta, usually called Bobbie, tried to understand the worry behind her mother’s tired face. Peter and Phyllis had questions too, but answers were scarce.

The railway gave them somewhere to explore. They watched trains, learned their times and waved to the passengers. One older gentleman waved back regularly. He became part of their days before they knew his name.

The station porter, Perks, also became a friend. Beyond the mystery in their own home, the children began discovering the lives connected by the railway.

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2. Mistakes and help

Cold weather and limited money made ordinary comforts harder to obtain. Peter tried taking coal from the railway, thinking he had found a practical solution. He was caught and had to understand that needing something did not make it his to take.

When their mother became ill, the children worried about the things the doctor said she needed. They made a large notice asking the old gentleman on the train to look out at the station.

Their message reached him, and he arranged help. Their mother was grateful but uncomfortable when she discovered how they had asked. She wanted them to understand the difference between friendship and treating strangers as a source of supplies.

The children were learning that good intentions did not answer every question about the way a thing was done. Still, their determination to care for their mother brought people into their lives who would matter later.

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3. The red flags

One day, the children saw that a landslip had blocked the railway line. A train would arrive before they could reach the station to report it.

They needed a warning the driver would recognise. The girls tore red fabric from their clothes, and the children made flags. They stood beside the line and waved desperately.

The driver saw them and stopped in time. An exciting place they had watched for entertainment had suddenly become a place where their actions could save lives.

The railway company thanked them. The old gentleman was among those who recognised what they had done. Bobbie was pleased, but the experience also taught her how quickly danger could approach people who had no idea it was there.

They had not planned to be brave. They had seen a problem and acted because there was nobody else close enough to act first.

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4. A stranger far from home

A distressed man arrived at the station speaking a language most people could not understand. The children took an interest in him instead of treating him as merely a nuisance.

Their mother could speak French with him. They learned that he was a Russian writer who had suffered imprisonment and separation from his family because of his political beliefs. He was trying to find them.

The family offered shelter, although they had little to spare. The children’s mother understood something about waiting for a person who could not simply come home when he wished.

With help from their growing circle of friends, the man was eventually reunited with his family. His presence made the world beyond the railway feel larger and more complicated.

The children still missed their own father. Their mother continued to protect them from the full explanation of his absence. But Bobbie was becoming old enough to notice when an unanswered question filled a whole

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room.

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5. A birthday for Perks

The children discovered that Perks did not expect much for his birthday. They went around the neighbourhood collecting gifts and useful things for his family.

They imagined only delight. Perks, however, was angry when he saw the collection. He believed he was being treated as a poor man receiving charity from people who looked down on him.

The children explained the messages that came with the presents. Neighbours remembered particular kindnesses and wanted to thank him. The gifts were not proof that he was helpless. They were evidence that people valued him.

Once he understood, the celebration became possible.

It was another lesson in how help could feel different to the person receiving it. The children had to listen to his pride instead of insisting that he should be grateful in exactly the way they expected.

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6. The tunnel and the newspaper

During a paper chase, a boy named Jim was injured in a railway tunnel. The children found him and arranged to get him out safely before another train arrived. Their mother helped care for him at home.

Jim turned out to be the old gentleman’s grandson. The friendship that had begun with waving from a field now connected their families directly.

Meanwhile, Bobbie saw an old newspaper and discovered the truth about her father. He had been accused of passing state secrets and was in prison.

She was shocked and went to her mother. Her mother believed firmly in his innocence. Bobbie promised not to tell the younger children, then wrote privately to the old gentleman asking for help.

He had influence, but she was asking for more than a favour. She was trusting him with the painful secret that had changed their whole life.

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7. The next arrival

Time passed. Bobbie continued her ordinary activities, but hope and fear accompanied them. A letter or an arriving train could mean more than anyone nearby realised.

Then something felt different. People at the station smiled at her in an unusual way. A train arrived, and through the steam she saw her father.

For a moment, she could hardly move. Then she ran towards him.

The charge had been overturned, and he was free. The old gentleman’s help had contributed to bringing the truth to light. Bobbie did not need a long explanation on the platform. She needed to reach the person she had missed.

She took him home to the others. The railway, which had carried strangers and possibilities through their difficult months, had finally brought the arrival they wanted most.

Their life had become smaller in possessions, but wider

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in friendships. They had learned that looking closely at the world could reveal both people who needed help and people willing to offer it.

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Words to keep

Porter — a railway worker who helps with goods, passengers or station tasks. Perks worked as a porter.

Landslip — earth and rocks sliding down a slope. A landslip blocked the track.

Influence — the ability to affect decisions or events. The old gentleman used his influence to help.

Accused — officially said to have done something wrong. Their father was accused of passing secrets.

Innocence — the state of not being guilty. Their mother believed in his innocence.

Reunite — to bring separated people together again. The family was reunited at last.

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A question to carry with you

Why does Perks first reject the birthday gifts? How could you offer help while respecting someone’s independence?

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